B2 Grammar

The passive voice

Form the passive in every tense and choose it when the action matters more than the person who did it.

We use the passive when the person who does the action is unknown, unimportant or obvious, and in formal writing such as reports and news. It is formed with *be* in the right tense + the past participle.

Tense	Active	Passive
Present simple	*They clean the rooms daily.*	*The rooms are cleaned daily.*
Past simple	*Someone stole my bike.*	*My bike was stolen.*
Present perfect	*They have cancelled the flight.*	*The flight has been cancelled.*
Present continuous	*They are building a new mall.*	*A new mall is being built.*
Future / modal	*They will announce the results.*	*The results will be announced.*

Adding the doer. Use *by* only when the doer is new or important: *The building was designed by Zaha Hadid.* Leave it out when it adds nothing: *My car was repaired* (by a mechanic, obviously).

Common mistakes. Forgetting *be*: *The letter sent yesterday* should be *The letter was sent yesterday*. Verbs with no object cannot be passive: *The accident was happened* is wrong; say *The accident happened*.

Practice

1. Make passive: People speak Arabic in many countries.
2. Make passive: The council has closed the road.
3. Make passive: They are repairing the bridge.
4. Correct the mistake: The meeting was happened on Monday.
5. Is "by" needed? The thief was arrested by the police.

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. Arabic is spoken in many countries.
2. The road has been closed (by the council).
3. The bridge is being repaired.
4. The meeting happened on Monday.
5. No. Only the police arrest people, so "The thief was arrested" is enough.